

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1991-04-21

To the bahá'ís of the world

1 Ridván 1991

To the bahá'ís of the world

2 dearly loved friends,

3 No earthly tongue can voice the gratitude we feel for the extraordinary

bestowals vouchsafed by the blessed beauty to his worldwide community

4 and to the world center of his faith during the year just ended. we bow

5 our heads in humility before the striking evidences of his sustaining grace

6 and all-compelling might.

7 The overwhelming danger which, as a result of the turmoil in the middle

8 east, enveloped the holy land during the latter part of the year receded

9 without halting or even seriously hampering the operation of the bahá'í

10 administration. The situation was a poignant reminder of the contrast between the unobtrusive, steadily developing, distinctly integrative System of

11 bahá'u'lláh and the turbulent character of the Age of Transition, "whose

12 tribulations," Shoghi effendi avers, "are the precursors of that era of blissful

13 107-3. The statement was published by the National Spiritual Assembly of the

14 bahá'ís of the united States under the title Bahá'u'lláh (Wilmette, IL: bahá'í

publishing Trust, 1991).107 .10

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109 message from The Universal House of Justice

110 1984 "felicity which is to incarnate God's ultimate purpose for all mankind." it was

111 another of the "ominous signs simultaneously proclaiming the agonies of a

112 disintegrating civilization and the birth pangs of that world order—that

Ark of human salvation—that must needs arise upon its ruins.”108-1

113 The forces which united the remedial reactions of so many nations to the
114 sudden crisis in this region demonstrated beyond any doubt the necessity of the
principle of collective security prescribed by bahá'u'lláh more than
115 a century ago as a means of resolving conflict. while the international ar-
116 rangement envisioned by him for the full application of this principle is far
117 from having been adopted by the rulers of mankind, a long step towards the behavior
outlined for the nations by the lord of the Age has thus been
118 taken. how illuminating are bahá'u'lláh's words foreshadowing the future
119 reorientation of the nations: “b e united, o concourse of the sovereigns of
120 the world,” he wrote, “for thereby will the tempest of discord be stilled
121 amongst you, and your peoples find rest. Should any one among you take
122 up arms against another, rise ye all against him, for this is naught but mani-fest
justice.”

123 108-2

124 indeed, from whatever direction we gaze, the power of bahá'u'lláh's rev-
125 elation is visibly at work in the world. in the call for a new world order,
126 which has issued like a refrain from the statements of political leaders and influential
thinkers, even when they themselves were incapable of defin-ing their own meaning, can be
discerned the slow awakening of humanity to the principal purpose of his revelation. That
such a call should have
127 come so insistently from the head of that republic which is destined, in ‘Abdu'l-b
ahá's words, to be “the first nation to establish the foundation of
128 international agreement” and to “lead all nations spiritually,” is an indica-tion of the
efficacy and the acceleration of two simultaneous processes, one
129 operating outside and one inside the cause, which Shoghi effendi tells us

are destined to culminate “in a single glorious consummation.”

130 108-3

within the cause, the signs of overwhelming achievements for the Six

131 year plan, though not necessarily as projected at the outset, are abundant.
132 Arresting examples are evident in the wake of the phenomenal changes oc-
133 curring in the Soviet union and its former satellite countries. just one year
134 since the reestablishment of the local Spiritual Assembly of moscow, a

135 108-1. wob, pp. 171, 155.

136 108-2. wob, p. 40.108-3. pup , pp. 49, 143; cf , p. 32.108.3

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109 1986–1992 • T h e S i x Y e a r P l a n

110 199National Spiritual Assembly of the Soviet union is to be formed. Similarly,

111 little more than a year since the revolutionary political changes in romania,

the government has recognized the bahá'í community as a religious as-

112 sociation with the right to spread the teachings of bahá'u'lláh; here, too, a

113 National Spiritual Assembly is to be formed this rixvân. rapid expansion

114 of the faith in czechoslovakia compelled the decision taken only in recent

115 weeks also to establish a National Spiritual Assembly there. At the same

116 time, in the caribbean area, the National Spiritual Assembly of the west

117 leeward islands will be formed as a result of the division of the leeward

118 islands group into two regional administrative units. with these four very

119 welcome formations, the number of National Spiritual Assemblies reaches 155.

we are happy to say that three hands of the cause of god will repre-

120 rú'íyyih khánúm in romania, mr. 'Alí Akbar furútan in the Soviet union,

121 and dr. 'Alí-m u'ġammad varqá in czechoslovakia. counselor ruth pringle

122 will be the representative in the w est leeward i slands.

123 Another illustration of the rising authority of the cause of bahá'u'lláh

in the public mind emerges from germany, where the federal constitu-

124 tional court, the highest legal authority in the land, rendered a decision of capital importance to the recognition of the faith. A series of lower courts

125 had refused to register the by-laws of a local Spiritual Assembly on the

126 grounds that the authority granted to the National Spiritual Assembly in that document violated the legal principle requiring the autonomy of all le-

127 gally incorporated associations. The issues involved are indeed complex and

128 cannot be elaborated here. Suffice it to say that the federal constitutional

129 court upheld the appeal of the local Spiritual Assembly in a long, closely

130 reasoned decision in which, among other things, it affirmed the right of

131 the bahá'í community to gain legal capacity in the very shape ordained in
 132 the scriptures of the bahá'í faith and stated that its nature as a recognized
 133 religion was unquestionably confirmed by its inherent character, by public
 134 knowledge, and by the testimony of scholars of comparative religion. So
 135 significant was the verdict in the court's own estimation that it took the
 136 rare step of issuing a statement to the press explaining its decision. This
 137 outstanding act will have implications for the bahá'í community far beyond
 138 the borders of a united Germany.
 139 yet another instance of the growing public appreciation for the penetrat-
 140 ing perspectives of the cause involves the republic of South Africa, where 108.6
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 109 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e
 110 200the National Spiritual Assembly, taking advantage of the initiatives of the
 111 government towards resolving the decades-long problem of apartheid,
 112 decided to submit its views for the drafting of a new constitution for the country. The
 president of the South African law commission, the judge
 113 acting on behalf of the government, who received the National Spiritual
 114 Assembly's submission from a delegation appointed by it, commented that
 115 the bahá'ís were the only group thus far whose ideas had provided a spiritual
 116 and moral foundation for a constitution.

whatever may be the individual effects of any one of these aforemen-

117 tioned developments—and of such others as the appearance of a represen-tative of
 the bahá'í international community as the only non-b uddhist
 118 speaker invited to address a public meeting held in conjunction with the
 119 Asian buddhist conference for peace in mongolia; the specific mention of
 120 the bahá'ís by pope john paul ii at a reception during his recent visit to bu-
 121 rundi; the official listing of the bahá'í faith as one of the common religions
 122 in T uvalu; the international exposition on education for peace sponsored
 123 by the brazilian National Spiritual Assembly with the participation of 23
 124 embassies and educational institutions—one thing is abundantly clear: the
 cumulative impact across the globe affirms the emergence of the faith from

125 obscurity. Such marks of increasing public recognition of the true character and rich
potentialities of the bahá'í community are a distinctive feature of

126 the advancement of the faith in the fourth epoch of the formative Age.

in contemplating these marvelous signs and portents, we cannot resist

127 the impulse to express our profound love and appreciation to the continen-

128 tal counselors, and to their Auxiliary boards, who stimulate and buttress ef-

129 forts which make possible the accomplishment of such stupendous develop-ments as
have already been cited and whose ministrations, more especially, spur the dynamic thrust
of the teaching work, which is fundamental to all

of the community's successes. we are delighted and encouraged beyond

measure by the vigorous beginning which the boards of counselors have

130 made as they entered the new term of their indispensable and highly ap-

131 preciated services to the bahá'í world. The fresh initiatives to which, with

132 the wholehearted encouragement and splendid support of the international

133 Teaching center, they now bend their energies augur well for a gratifying

134 completion of the Six year plan. may their exertions be greatly bolstered

135 by the increase, as of the day of the covenant this year, in the number

of Auxiliary board members to 846—90 more than exist at present. The

136 worldwide community will certainly welcome the strength which this action 108.9

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109 1986–1992 • The Six Year Plan

110 201 will bring to the scope and quality of the spiritual duties assigned to the

111 Auxiliary board members and their assistants, whose operation at the grass

112 roots is a guarantee of the continued expansion and consolidation of our glorious f
aith.

113 The magnificent progress of the Six year plan brightens our spirits and

114 exalts our hopes. All but one of the years of that plan have passed and a

115 mighty advance toward achieving its seven major objectives has been made. our
community has changed dramatically from what it was at the plan's be-

116 ginning in 1986. it has greatly expanded and developed. it is more diverse,

117 more dynamic, more distinctive. As we enter the closing year of the Six year

118 plan, a horizon of thrilling prospects stands before us all:

The preparation of the long-expected, annotated english transla-

tion of the kitáb-i-Aqdas, the book of laws, the most holy book,

the mother book of bahá'u'lláh's revelation, will be completed—a

monumental achievement which alone and of itself will usher in a new stage in the evolution of the bahá'í world and thus crown the

accomplishments of the Six year plan.

earthwork on the lower Terraces of the Shrine of the báb and ex-

cavation for the center for the Study of the Texts and the Annex to

the international Archives building will commence, initiating a new

phase of these mighty and incalculably significant enterprises on god's holy mountain.

The plan's end will mark the beginning of the holy year, 1992–1993,

a conscious year-long pause to allow his followers to pay befitting

regard to the centenary of the Ascension of bahá'u'lláh and of the

inauguration of his world-unifying covenant. As has already been

announced, major observances are being planned to reflect the distinctive character and world-shaking importance of the two occasions.

The one: the gathering of representatives of the bahá'í world, along

with knights of bahá'u'lláh, at bahjí in the precincts of the man-

sion, from whence bahá'u'lláh's liberated Spirit repaired to the throne

of his heavenly sovereignty, and in the vicinity of the most holy

Shrine, wherein the roll of honor of the knights of bahá'u'lláh will

be deposited as a gesture indicative of the response of his lovers to his 108.11

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202call to spread his teachings throughout the earth. There at bahjí this

gathering will engage in a solemn act of worship, the sacred readings

**for which will soon be shared with bahá'í communities everywhere for
use in their own commemorations, so as to unify the devotional ex-**
111 perience of the entire bahá'í world during this centennial observance.

The other: the world congress scheduled to be held on 23–26 No-
vember 1992 in New York City, where the beloved master revealed the
implications of his station as the appointed center of the covenant
112 of bahá'u'lláh and which he designated as the city of the covenant.

Throughout the world, bahá'í communities will hold appropriate aux-
113 iliary events to magnify the congress's purpose, which is to celebrate
the centenary of the inauguration of the covenant of bahá'u'lláh and
114 to proclaim its aims and unifying power. A corollary to these activities will be the
wide distribution of a statement on bahá'u'lláh, prepared at
115 our request by the office of public information, which will serve both
as a source of study and inspiration for the bahá'ís themselves and
116 as an informative publication for presentation to the public. In these
and other ways the community of the greatest Name will endeavor to
blazon the Name of bahá'u'lláh across the globe, to make it a known
117 eminence in the consciousness of peoples everywhere.

Such an exceptional confluence of imminent achievements—the publi-
118 cation of the Kitáb-i-Aqdas, the progress of the building projects on Mount
119 Carmel, the conclusion of the Six Year Plan, the inception of the Holy
120 Year—animates the expectations of the bahá'í world, sets the stage for
121 mightier endeavors than have already been attempted, and points us all to
122 the opening of a new phase of history. It seems fitting, then, that the sacred
123 law which enables each one to express his or her personal sense of devotion to God in
a profoundly private act of conscience that promotes the common
124 good, which directly connects the individual believer with the central in-
125 stitution of the faith, and which, above all, ensures to the obedient and the
126 sincere the ineffable grace and abundant blessings of providence, should,
127 at this favorable juncture, be embraced by all who profess their belief in the Supreme
manifestation of God. With humility before our sovereign

128 lord, we now announce that as of riḡvān 1992, the beginning of the holy
129 year, the law of ḡuqúqu'lláh, the right of god, will become universally

applicable. All are lovingly called to observe it.108.11e

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109 1986–1992 • T h e S i x Y e a r P l a n

110 20our very dear brothers and sisters: witness how the beloved one has an-
111 swered our entreaties. See how he has enriched our lives with new brethren
112 and new institutions in lands hitherto closed to his healing word. consider
113 with what potency his divine prescriptions are being affirmed as guidelines
114 for the behavior of nations large and small. Surely such abounding benedic-

tions have imbued you with indomitable courage and with confidence to

115 face a challenging but brilliant future. indeed, you have embarked on this
116 auspicious year poised for the ultimate triumph of the Six y ear p lan.

may you continue, through your selfless deeds in his service, to be

117 blessed from the inexhaustible treasury of h is love and tender care.

118 109

Acceptance of Bahá'u'lláh

and the Laws He Has Revealed

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]